which are tied a number of small balls studded with sharp bronze nails', accoutrements which were, however, never actually used.

Technological innovations developed alongside the ornamentation and a water tank, the Hauz-i Shirin, was built on a sharp slope and supported on inverted arches to hold the enormous weight of the stored water. Sweet water was required for human consumption and for cooking, to which Gangajal was added because Akbar strongly believed in the beneficial qualities of water from the Ganga. Wherever he happened to be in the empire, Gangajal was brought to Akbar in sealed jars, transported sometimes over long distances, because that was the only water he would drink. Akbar would have heard of the qualities of Gangajal, long revered in the country, through his Hindu wives and his Rajput noblemen. To Akbar, who would be haunted by the noxious spectre of poison, this would be one more measure, a divine one, to protect himself from harm.

An enormous workforce of labourers, stonemasons, stonecutters, stonecarvers, carpenters, diggers, wickerworkers, glassmakers, bricklayers, and various other craftsmen was mobilized as the city took shape at a rapid pace. To reduce the amount of noise created near the living quarters, Akbar ordered 'everything cleverly fashioned elsewhere, in accordance with the exact plan of the building, and then brought to the spot, and there fitted and fastened together'. As each building was completed, it was furnished too, with rich carpets on the floors and draperies on the walls and silk bolsters and cushions.

The unadorned red surfaces that bake in the summer sun today at Fatehpur Sikri give an inaccurate idea of what the palaces and buildings would have looked like. Instead of the unremitting expanse of red, there would instead have been colours and textures and textiles in glorious profusion as every surface and space was covered in paintings or wall hangings, carpets and tent awnings. There were frescoes and decorations on every surface, today sadly almost all degraded. Syed Ali Nadeem Rezavi has shown that the artists of Fatehpur Sikri used wall paintings extensively to cover almost every surface of the buildings with vibrant images. Wall paintings had been used since the time of Babur but it was under Akbar that these paintings were considered an essential part of architecture itself and encouraged accordingly. Artists used red ochre or black carbon to outline the paintings, filling in colours using minerals like lapis lazuli, sulphides of mercury, lead, and other arsenic and copper ores as well as plant extract